determined by their individual decisions: Based on market conditions, they must choose how much land they will plant, how many crops they will produce. Many, if not most, of these farmers prospered during the years of economic pestilence that ravaged the rest of American agriculture.

In the farm crisis of the mid-eighties, we gave farmers more billions than any administration in history. Frankly, I didn't relish giving so much of the taxpayers' money away, especially when we were battling to bring down the deficit. But farmers were facing a real emergency, and since government had produced many of their problems, I believed it had an obligation to help bail out the victims, then to work to return farming to the free market.

We made some progress in dealing with the problems in agriculture: In a bill I signed in 1985, Congress took large amounts of land that had been under the subsidy programs out of production, lowered the per-bushel subsidies farmers received, and offered other incentives that reduced farmers' reliance on subsidies. Together with improvements in the overall economy—reduced unemployment, lower inflation, and lower interest rates—the law helped American agriculture begin a historic turnaround: Within a year of its passage, farm revenues, profits, and exports were on the rise, while the amount of federal subsidies was in decline.

Between 1986 and 1989, subsidies fell from more than $25 billion annually to less than $10 billion. I wish I could have ended farm subsidies altogether—I still feel the answer is unfettered free competition—but, as I learned in Washington, you seldom get everything you want, and I'll settle for the progress we made.

There were other hardships in America during the long recession: In the emerald forests of the Pacific Northwest, loggers and sawmill workers saw thousands of jobs swallowed up by a prolonged slump in housing construction caused by bloated interest rates. In scores of tree-shaded